



OpenPantry

Volunteer Handbook

FOR VOLUNTEERS

How to open and run the checkout and Menu Counter stations.

Revised July 2026 • Version 1.0

© 2026 Chromagic Development • Bruce Alexander • MIT License

START HERE

Welcome

Thank you for volunteering! OpenPantry is the software the pantry uses to check food out the door, keep the shelves counted, and know what to reorder. You don't need any technical background — this handbook walks you through opening each station and handling the few moments where the app asks you to do something.

You'll mostly work at one of two stations: the **Scanning Station** (grocery-style checkout with a barcode scanner) or the **Menu Counter** (a tablet where shoppers tap the items they want and volunteers pick the order in back). Both are covered below.

GOLDEN RULE

If anything looks wrong — a frozen screen, a scanner that won't beep, a weight that won't save — don't force it. Note the order number if there is one and ask the administrator on duty. Nothing you tap here can break the data.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Getting on the stations

You do not need a password to run the scanning station or the Menu Counter. Those screens are locked to the pantry's own network address (its IP), so simply being on the pantry Wi-Fi is what authorizes them — they open straight to the work screen.

- The stations only work while you're on the **pantry's Wi-Fi**. On any other network the app shows an "Access Denied" screen — that's expected, not a login you're missing.
- OpenPantry may also be set to **open only during pantry hours**. Outside those hours you'll see "Access is closed right now." Try again during service.
- A password is only requested on **administrator** screens — item setup, Settings, reports, and the delivery client list. Volunteers don't use those day to day; if you land on one by mistake, back out and ask the administrator.

Open-the-Station Checklist — Scanning Station

Work top to bottom. Tick each box as you go.

- | | |
|--------------------------|---|
| ☐ | Power on the Chromebook tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi (the scanner only works on the pantry network) if it is not already connected. |
| ☐ | Make sure the handheld barcode scanner is connected to the tablet; wait for its ready beep / steady LED. |
| ☐ | Power on the produce scale and complete the “PC” setup below if it is not already set. |
| ☐ | Open the browser and go to the OpenPantry Scan (Laser) page. It opens straight to the scanner — no password is needed, because the pantry network authorizes the station. |
| ☐ | Scan any item's barcode as a test — a “Last scan” line should appear. Then tap the red × Cancel Order so the test doesn't count. |
| ☐ | Tap once inside the barcode box so the cursor sits there (it glows green when focused). |

Configuring the produce scale (one-time, each power-on)

The VEVOR scale with RS232 Port connects to the tablet as a USB keyboard. After you power it on it must be switched into “**PC**” mode so it types weights straight into OpenPantry. Do this every time the scale is powered up:

1	Power on the scale and let it settle to 0 .	Zero / stable reading
2	Press the [.] (period / decimal) key.	Enters setup
3	Wait until the display reads “ Entr ”.	Ready for unit
4	Press [2] to set the unit to “ lb ”.	Unit = lb
5	Press [.] (period), then press [9].	Selects PC interface
6	Confirm the weight window shows “ PC ”.	Interfaced to OpenPantry

WHEN YOU SEE “PC”, YOU'RE SET

That reading means the scale is now talking to OpenPantry. Place a produce item on the scale during a scan and its weight fills the weight box automatically — no typing. If the window ever drops back to a plain weight, repeat the steps above.

Running the Scanning Station

Starting and ending an order

- 1 You don't press "start" — the **first item you scan** automatically opens a new order and assigns it a number (shown large at the top).
- 2 Scan every item the shopper is taking — or add it by name if it won't scan (see below). Each entry drops into the list with a beep.
- 3 When they're done, tap ■ **End Order**. The counts are subtracted from inventory. (You can also scan the special **End Order** command barcode if your station has one posted.)
- 4 Made a mistake? Tap the red ✕ next to a line to remove that scan, or tap ✕ **Cancel Order** to throw the whole order away.

Adding an item by name (no barcode needed)

No barcode, a barcode that won't scan, or loose produce with no sticker? You can add the item by **typing its name** instead. The entry box is labeled **Barcode or Item Name** — start typing and, after two letters, matching items from the catalog appear beneath it as you type. When your text matches a single item, press **Enter** (or Tab) to record it, exactly as if you'd scanned it. Digits on their own are still treated as a barcode, so typing a name never interferes with the scanner.

FASTEST FIX FOR A TORN OR MISSING BARCODE

If a label is smudged or peeled off, don't hunt for the number — just type the first few letters of the item's name and pick it from the list.

What you don't need to scan

You don't have to capture everything a shopper takes. The scan data drives reordering of the core, regularly-stocked staples, so a few categories can be **safely ignored**:

- **High-calorie items with low nutritional value** — e.g. candy, sweets, or desserts.
- **Packaged meals and sandwiches.**
- **Anything that doesn't appear to be regularly stocked** — one-off donations and oddments.

If you're unsure whether something is a regularly-stocked staple, ask the administrator.

When the app asks for a weight (produce)

Fruits and vegetables are often sold by weight rather than count, so after you scan a produce code a weight box pops up and the station beeps:

- **Using the scale:** just set the item on the scale. If it's in "PC" mode (see the checklist) the weight fills in by itself — confirm and it saves.
- **By hand:** type **1 digit for pounds, then 2 digits for ounces**. Example: typing **514** means 5 lb 14 oz. Backspace fixes a slip; press Enter or **Save Weight**.

When the app doesn't recognize a barcode

Occasionally a packaged item isn't in the catalog. A box appears asking you to **Identify this item**. Type a short, plain **generic name** (e.g. "Canned Tuna", not the brand) and tap **Save & Record**. The app remembers it for next time. If you're unsure of the name, ask the administrator.

KEEP THE CURSOR IN THE BOX

The scanner types like a keyboard, so the barcode box must stay selected (it glows green). If scans stop registering, tap once inside that box and try again.

Open-the-Station Checklist — Menu Counter

The Menu Counter has two screens: the **customer order form** that shoppers tap, and the **pick queue** that volunteers pull from in the back.

Customer-facing tablet

Power on the customer tablet and connect it to the pantry Wi-Fi.

Open the browser to the OpenPantry **Menu Counter** order form. It opens directly — **no password** to enter.

Confirm the page loads the item buttons grouped by category (Dairy, Dry Goods, Frozen, ...).

Set the language selector back to English so the next shopper starts fresh.

Stand the tablet in its holder facing the shopper; clean the screen.

Pick-queue tablet / screen (back of house)

Open the **Menu Counter** → **Orders** (pick queue) page on the volunteer screen. It opens directly — **no password** needed.

Confirm the queue auto-refreshes and the topbar shows “pending orders” and “items remaining”.

Submit one test order from the customer tablet and confirm it appears in the queue, then Mark Complete to clear it.

Make sure bags/bins and a pen are staged at the pick bench.

NO LOGIN ON THE PANTRY NETWORK

The Menu Counter order form and pick queue are secured by the pantry's network address, not a password, so volunteers never log in to use them. A password is only asked for on the administrator's **item-setup** screen — leave that to the person opening the pantry.

ORDERS & PICKING

Running the Menu Counter

Helping a shopper at the order form

- Shoppers tap the food items they want; selected items highlight. Items marked unavailable show but can't be picked.
- Besides entering their first name, they enter how many **adults** and **children** are in the household — the app uses that to set quantities automatically.

- Some items ask for a size (e.g. diapers) — a dropdown appears when the item is selected.
- A translate button lets shoppers switch languages; the form returns to English after each order so the next person starts fresh.
- When they submit, a confirmation appears and the order drops into the pick queue in back.

Picking an order in back

- 1** New orders appear in the queue sidebar with a progress bar. Tap one to open its list.
- 2** Gather each item and **tap it to mark it picked** (it turns green with a check).
- 3** Use **+** to add another of an item, or **×** to remove one that's out of stock or entered accidentally.
- 4** Once every item is checked, tap **Mark Complete** to clear the order from the queue.
- 5** The queue refreshes on its own every 30 seconds — no need to reload.

DELIVERIES & EVENTS

Other channels you may see

Some volunteers help with home **Deliveries** or **Events** (community meals). These use their own simple forms reached from the top menu under **Checkout**. The pattern is the same: pick the items and counts, then submit. A volunteer lead will show you the delivery rotation and printing steps — and remember that client names, addresses, and phone numbers are private (see below).

EVERY SHIFT

Privacy & closing up

Protecting shopper privacy

- Never share or write down a shopper's name, address, or phone number outside the app.
- Don't leave a logged-in tablet unattended where the public can reach the reports.

Closing the station

	Finish or cancel any order still open on the scanning station (the top should read “not started”).
	Clear any leftover orders from the Menu Counter pick queue.
	Log out (the ■ Log out link, top right) if you're leaving the tablet in a public spot if the admin is signed into the app.
	There is no need to power off the equipment, but make sure the tablets are on their chargers.
	Tell the administrator about anything odd that happened during the shift.

THANK YOU

Every order you check out becomes data that helps the pantry order smarter and show donors the real need. Your careful scanning literally keeps the shelves stocked.